



Stonehenge in western Britain was a ceremonial site from around 3100 BCE. An early earth enclosure and a circle of wooden posts were later replaced by the outer circle of stones seen here.

DURING THE LAST HALF OF THE FOURTH MILLENNIUM BCE, the world's first civilizations arose, first in Western Asia, then North Africa and South Asia. Civilization also appeared in China in the early second millennium BCE. By 3000 BCE, **the world's first urban culture** had begun to develop in southern **Mesopotamia**, in what is now Iraq. The lower Euphrates river plains had been farmed from c. 6200 BCE, after the development of irrigation systems—the Greek word *mesopotamia* means “land between the rivers.” By 3500 BCE, farming communities were growing into towns and then cities such as Ur, Uruk, and Eridu. Over the next 300 years, each city came to dominate its surrounding area, forming a group of city-states in the land called Sumer in southeast Mesopotamia.

Metalworking had begun in Mesopotamia around 6000 BCE. Around 3200 BCE, Sumerian

50 THOUSAND THE POPULATION OF THE CITY OF URUK c. 2800 BCE

smiths began **manufacturing bronze**. The plow had been in use since about 5000 BCE, wheeled carts from around 3500 BCE, and such advances made farming more productive. The resulting food surplus freed some people from the farming life, allowing **specialization into professions** such as priesthood, crafts, trade, and administration. The **world's first tiered society** developed, headed by kings sometimes known as lugal.

In **Egypt**, one of the world's **most complex ancient civilizations** was forming along the banks of the Nile River by 3100 BCE. The Nile formed a narrow strip of cultivatable land, floodplain, as the

river's annual flood (known as the inundation) spread black silt along its banks. The Egyptian farming year began in the fall when the inundation subsided, and farmers cultivated wheat, barley, beans, and lentils in the fertile soil.

By the end of the 4th millennium BCE, farming communities had evolved into two kingdoms: **Upper Egypt** in the south and **Lower Egypt** in the north. **King Narmer** united the two kingdoms c. 3100 BCE.

After Narmer came **Menes**, although historians are unsure whether Menes was Narmer's successor or a different name for Narmer himself. Menes is credited with founding the Egyptian capital at Memphis and Egypt's first dynasty.

As in Mesopotamia, efficient agriculture produced prosperity and specialism, allowing **arts, crafts, engineering, and early medicine** to develop.

The Early Dynastic Period (c. 3100–2686 BCE) was already characterized by many of the celebrated aspects of Egyptian culture: **hieroglyphic** writing, a sophisticated **religion** (including belief in an afterlife), and preserving the dead using **mummification**. A complex hierarchical society developed, with the king at the apex accorded semi-divine status. Egyptian kings—later known as **pharaohs**—ruled with the help of a chief minister, or vizier, regional governors (nomarchs), and a huge staff of lesser officials including priests, tax collectors, and scribes.

In **China**, civilization originated in the valleys of eastern rivers such as the Huang He (Yellow River), where the rich loess soil

made the land fertile. As early as 8000 BCE, millet had been cultivated in the area around Yangshao in Henan Province. Around c. 2400 BCE, the neighboring Dawenkou culture developed into the **Longshan culture** of Shangdong Province. Longshan farmers grew rice after developing irrigation systems. As in other early civilizations, agricultural success allowed the development of an elaborate society. Chinese craftsmen were making **bronze tools** c. 3000 BCE, **jade vessels** c. 2700 BCE, and **silk weaving** had begun by 3500 BCE.

The **Bronze Age** was underway in western Asia by 3000 BCE, and possibly considerably earlier. The Bronze Age in Europe seems to have developed separately from around 2500 BCE, using ore sources from the Carpathian Mountains in Central Europe. This era also saw the beginnings of the **Minoan civilization** on the Greek island of Crete around 2000 BCE, with trading links to the nearby Cyclades Islands and the wider Mediterranean. In Western Europe, the earlier tradition of megalithic tomb building and a growing interest in astronomical observation gave rise to a new **megalithic tradition** of erecting stone circles, stone rows, standing stones, and tombs including astronomical features. **These include** Newgrange in Ireland, Stonehenge in England, and Carnac in France.



Ancient cities of Mesopotamia

Sumer in southern Mesopotamia was the location of the world's first urban civilization from c. 2900 BCE as agricultural success led to a complex society.

KEY

- Extent of Early Dynastic city-states
- Ancient coastline



Narmer Palette

This carved piece of green siltstone records the triumph of the legendary King Narmer of Upper Egypt over his enemies.

